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SATURDAY, 03 OCTOBER 2026

19 must-know stories, 21 Prelims facts, 15 editorials and 12 explainers, picked from 659 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

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MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Polity & Constitution

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Rajya Sabha passes Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026

The Bill came into focus after being passed by the Rajya Sabha on October 3, 2026. The Rajya Sabha has successfully passed the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026.

When: 2026-10-03 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Rajya Sabha · **Prelims:** The Bill passed is the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026.; The house that passed the Bill in the report is the Rajya Sabha.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Strengthens legal deterrents against the desecration of national symbols.; Updates older legislative frameworks to better address contemporary instances of disrespect.*

Static — The Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act was originally enacted in 1971 to prevent desecration of national symbols. The Act penalizes insults to the Indian National Flag, the Constitution of India, and the National Anthem. Offences under the original Act carry punishments including imprisonment up to three years, fines, or both.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

First India: read the source · also reported by DD News, Insights on India

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Gujarat UCC Bill Gets President's Assent; Registration Of Live-In Relationships, Penalties For...

President Droupadi Murmu has given assent to the Gujarat Uniform Civil Code (UCC), 2026, creating a common civil law framework for the state. The Gujarat government notified the law in the state gazette on October 1, though it will come into force on a separately notified date. The legislation covers marriage, divorce, succession, and live-in relationships, aiming to provide a uniform set of civil rules irrespective of religion. Couples must submit a memorandum for mandatory marriage registration within 60 days, with penalties prescribed for non-compliance. Registration is also mandatory for live-in relationships, where children born from such unions are recognised as legitimate. The Code grants maintenance rights to women abandoned by live-in partners and penalises false information with up to three months imprisonment or a fine of up to Rs 25,000. The law repeals the Gujarat Registration of Marriages Act, 2006, and overrides inconsistent provisions in existing state laws. Scheduled Tribes and communities whose traditional rights are protected under Part XXI of the Constitution are explicitly exempted from the law.

When: October 1, 2026 · **Where:** Gujarat · **Who:** President Droupadi Murmu, Gujarat Government · **Prelims:** The Gujarat Uniform Civil Code, 2026, was published in the state gazette on October 1.; Marriage registration memorandum must be submitted within 60 days.; Furnishing false live-in registration information attracts imprisonment of up to three months or a fine up to Rs 25,000.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Marks a major legislative step by a state towards implementing a Uniform Civil Code under Article 44 of the Directive Principles.; Introduces formal legal oversight, mandatory registration, and maintenance protections for live-in relationships.*

Static — Article 44 of the Indian Constitution, enshrined under the Directive Principles of State Policy, directs the State to secure for citizens a Uniform Civil Code throughout the territory of India. A Uniform Civil Code proposes to replace personal laws based on the scriptures and customs of each major religious community in India with a common set governing all citizens. Personal laws traditionally cover matters like marriage, divorce, inheritance, adoption, and maintenance, which have historically varied across Hindu, Muslim, Christian, and Parsi communities.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Act/Bill/Rules

msn.com: read the source · also reported by t.co, The Times of India

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Centre frames rules to standardise recruitment to various tribunal posts

Appointments to 16 tribunals and appellate bodies will now move to one uniform set of rules run by an independent National Tribunals Commission (NTC). The Union Law Ministry issued the National Tribunals Commission and Qualification, Selection and Conditions of Service of Chairperson and Members of Tribunals Rules, 2026. This reform follows Supreme Court interventions striking down parts of the Tribunals Reforms Act, 2021 for violating judicial independence. The NTC aims to bring uniformity, efficiency, transparency, and freedom from executive pressure in tribunal appointments. Headquartered in Delhi, the NTC consists of a chairperson who is a retired Supreme Court judge or High Court Chief Justice, plus four members split equally between judicial and technical backgrounds. The rules mandate that recruitment for a vacancy must begin at least six months before the post falls vacant. The NTC chairperson will receive a monthly salary of Rs. 2.5 lakh, while each member will receive Rs. 2.25 lakh. A formal inquiry mechanism has been established to handle complaints of misconduct against tribunal members. Concerns remain because the executive continues to write service rules, and tribunals still depend on parent ministries for budgets and staff.

When: 2026-10-03 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Union Law Ministry, National Tribunals Commission · **Prelims:** The NTC is headquartered in Delhi.; The NTC chairperson receives a monthly salary of Rs. 2.5 lakh.; Each NTC member receives a monthly salary of Rs. 2.25 lakh.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Replaces fragmented recruitment arrangements with a uniform, independent selection mechanism for 16 tribunals.; Addresses chronic delays by mandating that recruitment must begin at least six months before a vacancy arises.*

Static — Tribunals are quasi-judicial bodies established to deal with specific disputes, reducing the burden on regular courts and providing speedy justice. Article 323A and Article 323B of the Constitution of India empower Parliament and state legislatures to set up administrative and other tribunals. The landmark L. Chandra Kumar v. Union of India (1997) Supreme Court judgment held that the power of judicial review vested in High Courts under Article 226 and 227 is a basic feature of the Constitution.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution

civilsdaily.com: read the source · also reported by illustrated Daily News

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Supreme Court Refers Constitutional Issues Regarding Governance of National Capital Territory of Delhi to Constitution Bench. The court recognized the need for clarity in the distribution of powers between the elected government and the Lieutenant Governo

The matter came into focus as the court acknowledged the pressing need for legal clarity on executive powers between Delhi's elected government and the Lieutenant Governor. The Supreme Court has referred the constitutional issues surrounding the governance and distribution of powers in the National Capital Territory of Delhi to a Constitution Bench.

When: 2026-10-03 · **Where:** National Capital Territory of Delhi · **Who:** Supreme Court of India, Elected Government of Delhi, Lieutenant Governor · **Prelims:** The case involves the governance of the National Capital Territory of Delhi.; The issues were referred to a Constitution Bench by the Supreme Court.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Crucial for defining the federal and administrative balance in India's national capital.; Sets a major judicial precedent for the interpretation of special governance provisions for Union Territories.*

Static — Article 239AA of the Constitution provides special provisions for Delhi, creating a Legislative Assembly and a Council of Ministers. The Lieutenant Governor acts as the administrative head of Delhi, functioning under the aid and advice of the Council of Ministers on matters within the assembly's legislative competence. Power disputes between the elected government and the Centre's appointed Lieutenant Governor have frequently led to prolonged judicial battles.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

Lawtext: read the source · also reported by lawtext.in

Governance & Policy

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

India’s first digital enumeration Census 2027 to boost data-driven policymaking

Census 2027 will be India’s first fully digital enumeration using mobile-based data collection for reliable and comprehensive data. The Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs decided to include caste enumeration in Census 2027, moving beyond only SCs and STs. The exercise features near real-time monitoring through the CMMS portal, an optional self-enumeration facility, and geo-referenced jurisdictions. The Census is backed by an approved financial outlay of Rs. 11,718.24 crore and strengthened data-security arrangements. Data centres designated as Critical Information Infrastructure (CII) will be utilized to secure the large-scale data collection process. The exercise will be conducted in a structured two-phase format to ensure comprehensive and systematic data collection nationwide. Census 2027 will be the eighth census conducted since independence and stands as the largest census exercise globally. The collected data supports resource allocation, targeted scheme delivery, and planning across sectors like food, water, and energy.

When: 2027 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs · **Prelims:** Census 2027 is India's eighth census since independence.; The approved financial outlay for Census 2027 is Rs. 11,718.24 crore.; The Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs decided to include caste enumeration in the Census.

Why it matters — *Enables data-driven policymaking and targeted delivery of government welfare schemes through granular local-level insights.; Integrates modern technology such as mobile applications, geo-referencing, and Critical Information Infrastructure-designated data centres.*

Static — The Census in India is the primary and most reliable source of demographic, social, and economic data. Census exercises in India are conducted under the provisions of the Census Act, 1948. The responsibility of conducting the decennial census rests with the Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner, India, under the Ministry of Home Affairs.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Report/Index

ddnews.gov.in: read the source

International Relations

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

India’s Effort to Revise its Model Bilateral Investment Treaty (BIT)

India is reviewing its Model Bilateral Investment Treaty (BIT) after a decade of the 2015 model to create a more investor-friendly structure and attract sustained foreign investment. The 2015 model faced severe criticism and negotiation deadlocks due to its overly prescriptive nature, leading over 70 countries to terminate their existing BITs with India. The core issue centers on balancing robust foreign investor protection with India's sovereign right to regulate and safeguard domestic public interest. A major controversial provision in the 2015 model requires foreign investors to exhaust local legal remedies in Indian courts for five years before seeking international arbitration. Recent agreements like the India-UAE and India-Israel BITs have shown flexibility by reducing the local remedy exhaustion period to three years. The Ministry of Finance has completed assessing the revised model and sent it to the Cabinet Secretariat for approval to help conclude talks with nations like Canada. The revision comes amid weaker FDI trends, with net FDI inflows projected at $12 billion in the first half of 2026. Recommended changes include clarifying Most Favoured Nation clauses, introducing investor obligations and state counterclaims, and simplifying dispute resolution mechanisms.

When: 2026-10-03 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Ministry of Finance · **Prelims:** The current Indian BIT model was approved in December 2015 and adopted in January 2016.; Net FDI inflows are projected at $12 billion in the first half of 2026.; The India-Israel Bilateral Investment Agreement entered into force in July 2026.

Why it matters — *Crucial for reviving stalled international investment treaty negotiations with nations like Canada.; Helps reverse weaker foreign direct investment (FDI) trends by offering a balanced, predictable dispute resolution environment.*

Static — A Bilateral Investment Treaty (BIT) is a reciprocal agreement between two countries to promote and protect foreign investments in each other's territories. Investor-State Dispute Settlement (ISDS) is a mechanism that allows foreign investors to bring arbitration claims against host governments for treaty breaches. The Exhaustion of Local Remedies (ELR) rule requires foreign entities to utilize domestic legal and administrative judicial systems before triggering international arbitration.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: International Relations · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

NEXT IAS: read the source

GS2 MAKE NOTES

Fact sheet: Quad unveils major Indo-Pacific initiatives on maritime security, critical minerals and emerging technologies

The Quad nations announced major initiatives for maritime security, critical minerals, digital connectivity, energy resilience, and emerging technologies in the Indo-Pacific. The announcements occurred during the 11th Quad Foreign Ministers Meeting held in New Delhi. The partners launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Collaboration to enhance maritime domain awareness and information sharing. Australia will host a Quad Counterterrorism Tabletop Exercise in June 2026 focusing on state-sponsored terrorism and misuse of unmanned aerial vehicles. The Quad Critical Minerals Initiative Framework was unveiled to strengthen resilient supply chains through coordinated investments and recycling cooperation. The Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security was launched to focus on energy technology, policy, and emergency response exercises. The Quad announced collaboration with Fiji on port infrastructure development and aims to connect all Pacific Islands Forum countries via undersea cables by 2026. Under the AI-ENGAGE initiative, the Quad provided over USD 6 million for six international research projects improving crop yields and food security.

When: 2026-10-03 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** S. Jaishankar, Penny Wong, Toshimitsu Motegi, Marco Rubio · **Prelims:** The 11th Quad Foreign Ministers Meeting was held in New Delhi.; The Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Collaboration was launched as a first-ever initiative.; Australia will host the Quad Counterterrorism Tabletop Exercise in June 2026.

Why it matters — *Strengthens India's strategic partnership in the Indo-Pacific region against maritime and security challenges.; Boosts technology cooperation, resilient supply chains for critical minerals, and digital connectivity.*

Static — The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue, or Quad, is an informal strategic forum comprising India, the United States, Japan, and Australia. The grouping traces its origins back to the 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami relief coordination and was revived in 2017. The Quad aims to ensure and support a free, open, and inclusive Indo-Pacific region, countering strategic and economic coercion.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Infrastructure & Energy

ddnews.gov.in: read the source

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

Weaponisation of SWIFT and the response of Russia, China and BRICS

SWIFT is a global messaging network founded in 1973 connecting over 11,000 financial institutions for secure international money and securities transfers. The US, EU, UK and allies weaponised SWIFT to enforce sanctions, notably excluding major Russian financial institutions after the 2022 Ukraine invasion. The core issue is weaponising financial interdependence to choke resources, exemplified by freezing over $300 billion of Russian foreign exchange assets. Sanctions also targeted Venezuela, cutting its access to global banking, freezing $2 billion in gold by the Bank of England, and seeking regime change. Russia countered SWIFT exclusion by demanding Ruble-for-gas payments in local currencies and developing its SPFS messaging system connected across 20 countries. China introduced the Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS) in 2015 to internationalize the Yuan and reduce reliance on SWIFT and the US dollar. CIPS has grown significantly, processing around 80 trillion yuan in a single year with about 1,280 financial institutions from 103 countries connected.

When: 2026-10-03 · **Where:** Global · **Who:** US, EU, Russia, China, Venezuela, Bank of England · **Prelims:** SWIFT was founded in 1973 as an alternative to the telex system.; Russia introduced the SPFS system as an alternative to SWIFT.; China launched the Cross-Border Interbank Payment System (CIPS) in 2015.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Highlights the vulnerability of emerging economies to Western-dominated financial networks.; Shows the gradual de-dollarization and creation of alternative financial architectures by BRICS nations.*

Static — SWIFT was founded in 1973 to replace the telex system, providing a secure global messaging network for financial institutions across more than 200 countries and territories. SPFS is Russia's domestic financial messaging system created by the Central Bank of Russia as an alternative to SWIFT to bypass Western sanctions. CIPS is China's Cross-Border Interbank Payment System launched in 2015 to clear and settle transactions in Chinese Yuan, promoting its internationalization.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: International Relations

thehansindia.com: read the source

Economy

GS3 MAKE NOTES

RBI rate hikes back on the table as inflation risks mount

Economists and analysts expect the RBI may hike the repo rate by 25 basis points to 5.50 percent in its upcoming October meeting. The central bank had previously left the repo rate unchanged at 5.25 percent during its August 2026 meeting while retaining a neutral stance. If implemented, this would mark the first repo rate increase by the central bank since February 2023. Analysts note that factors influencing the Monetary Policy Committee's decision include inflation, crude oil prices, and the movement of the Indian rupee. Real estate experts argue that maintaining a stable policy environment helps sustain housing demand linked to sectors like steel and cement. An unexpected rate hike and hawkish guidance could put near-term pressure on equity benchmarks like Nifty and Sensex by raising borrowing costs. Market participants will closely watch the policy announcement and guidance on October 7 to assess whether the tightening cycle will extend further.

When: October 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Pradeep Aggarwal, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) · **Prelims:** The previous repo rate was kept unchanged at 5.25 percent at the August 2026 meeting.; The potential rate increase under discussion is 25 basis points to 5.50 percent.; The October MPC meeting is scheduled for October 5-7, with the policy decision due on October 7.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Affects borrowing costs for homebuyers and overall housing sector momentum.; Influences corporate financing expenses, credit demand, and equity market sentiment.*

Static — The Monetary Policy Committee is a statutory body constituted under Section 45ZB of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934, to determine the policy interest rate required to achieve the inflation target. The repo rate is the interest rate at which the central bank lends money to commercial banks in the event of any shortfall of funds. Inflation targeting mandates the RBI to maintain consumer price inflation within a targeted band, currently set at 4 percent with a tolerance band of +/- 2 percent.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Governance & Policy, Geography · Prelims angle: Data/Stats, Report/Index

Mint: read the source · *free copy on msn.com*

GS3 MAKE NOTES

NABKISAN Lists India’s First WASH-Focused Social Bond, Raises Rs. 180 Crore

NABKISAN Finance Ltd listed India's first social bond dedicated exclusively to the Water, Sanitation, and Hygiene sector. The listing took place on the National Stock Exchange in Mumbai on October 1, 2026. The issue raised Rs. 180 crore and was structured as a five-year bond with a coupon rate of 8.10% maturing in September 2031. The bond issue was oversubscribed 1.8 times, showing strong investor demand beyond the amount offered. The instrument received CRISIL AAA (Stable) and CARE AAA (Stable), the highest domestic credit ratings assigned by these agencies. The proceeds will be deployed to expand safe water, sanitation, and hygiene solutions across rural and underserved communities. Water.org acted as the technical advisor and knowledge partner for the transaction. The initiative demonstrates how capital market instruments can mobilise resources for critical development sectors with measurable social impact.

When: 2026-10-03 · **Where:** Mumbai · **Who:** NABKISAN Finance Ltd, NABARD, Water.org · **Prelims:** NABKISAN Finance Ltd is a subsidiary of NABARD.; The WASH-focused social bond was listed on the National Stock Exchange (NSE) in Mumbai.; The bond raised Rs. 180 crore with

a coupon rate of 8.10% and maturity in September 2031.

Why it matters — *Demonstrates the viability of innovative financing mechanisms to address critical social infrastructure needs in rural India.; Mobilises commercial and capital market resources toward developmental sectors through sustainable finance.*

Static — NABARD, the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development, was established in 1982 under the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development Act, 1981. NABARD acts as an apex development bank in India, facilitating credit for agriculture and rural development. Social bonds are fixed-income debt instruments designed to raise capital exclusively for projects with positive social outcomes.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Health, Agriculture & Allied · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

PIB: read the source · free copy on gktoday.in

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Indias Forex Reserves Decline by $18.3 Billion, Biggest Weekly Fall on Record, Reveals RBI Data

India's foreign exchange reserves declined by $18.3 billion to $747.6 billion during the week ended September 25, marking the biggest weekly fall on record. The sharp decline was primarily driven by a drop in Foreign Currency Assets (FCAs) by $15.6 billion to $615.4 billion. Other components also decreased, including gold reserves by $2.6 billion, Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) by $97 million, and IMF reserve position by $86 million. The fall in reserves occurred as the Reserve Bank of India intervened in the foreign exchange market through dollar sales to support the rupee. The rupee dropped by 0.5% to close at 96.3150 per dollar on October 1, reaching its weakest level in two months. Higher crude oil prices, rising US Treasury yields, and the ongoing crisis in West Asia have put continuous pressure on the rupee. Experts have warned that the rupee could weaken further to 100 per US dollar or beyond if the crisis in West Asia persists.

When: September 25 to October 2, 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India · **Prelims:** Reserves fell by $18.3 billion to $747.6 billion for the week ended September 25.; Foreign Currency Assets declined by $15.6 billion to $615.4 billion.; Gold reserves fell by $2.6 billion to $108.7 billion.

Why it matters — *Highlights the immense pressure on India's external sector amid rising crude prices and global geopolitical tensions.; Demonstrates the cost of RBI interventions in currency markets to defend the sliding rupee.*

Static — Foreign exchange reserves are external assets held in foreign currencies by central banks and monetary authorities to back liabilities. The Reserve Bank of India manages India's forex reserves under the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934. Components of India's forex reserves include Foreign Currency Assets (FCAs), Gold, Special Drawing Rights (SDRs), and Reserve Position with the IMF.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

m.thewire.in: read the source · also reported by Economic Times

GS3 MAKE NOTES

Samudra Manthan Mission: India’s Rs. 84,084-Crore Push for Deep-Sea Hydrocarbon Exploration

Details emerged regarding the operationalisation of the Rs. 84,084-crore Samudra Manthan National Offshore Exploration Scheme to expand hydrocarbon exploration into deep offshore frontier waters. The initiative is triggered by massive import dependency, as India is the world's third-largest consumer of crude oil with an annual import bill of nearly $144 billion. Mature domestic fields like Mumbai High experience natural production declines of 6% to 7% annually, necessitating continuous new discoveries to sustain output. The Central Sector initiative by the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas runs with an outlay of Rs. 84,084 crore till FY 2030-31. It allocates Rs. 43,200 crore for 60 exploration wells and Rs. 28,534 crore for offshore seismic surveys, data processing, and geological interpretation. The scheme targets the Mahanadi, Andaman-Nicobar, Krishna-Godavari, Cauvery, and Kutch-Mumbai basins for deep and ultra-deep exploration. It also provides Rs. 2,000 crore for indigenous equipment and service clusters under Make in India alongside Rs. 350 crore for regulatory support. The mission aims to add over 600 MMTOE of recoverable reserves, raise domestic production to 80 MMTOE annually, and reduce crude import dependence.

When: FY 2030-31 · **Where:** Mahanadi, Andaman-Nicobar, Krishna-Godavari, Cauvery, Kutch-Mumbai basins · **Who:** Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, ONGC, Oil India, ExxonMobil · **Prelims:** Outlay of Rs. 84,084 crore till FY 2030-31 under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas.; Allocates Rs. 43,200 crore for 60 exploration wells and Rs. 28,534 crore for seismic surveys.; First appraisal well MN-DWN18-1-HD in Mahanadi basin spudded in July 2026.

Why it matters — *Aims to add over 600 MMTOE of recoverable reserves and raise domestic production to 80 MMTOE annually.; Expected to cut crude import expenditure by nearly Rs. 1 lakh crore annually.*

Static — The Hydrocarbon Exploration and Licensing Policy (HELP) replaced the older New Exploration Licensing Policy (NELP) in 2016, introducing an open acreage licensing policy and revenue-sharing model. The Open Acreage Licensing Programme (OALP) allows companies to carve out blocks of their choice throughout the year by submitting expressions of interest. India's Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) extends up to 200 nautical miles from the baseline, providing sovereign rights for exploring and exploiting marine resources.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Scheme, Data/Stats

insightsonindia.com: read the source

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India weathered global shocks, retained policy space to respond: FM Nirmala Sitharaman

The Finance Minister made these remarks during her assessment of India's economic performance and resilience against global shocks. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman highlighted India's robust economic resilience, citing a 7.8 percent Q1 FY27 GDP growth and USD 766 billion in forex reserves. Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said India's economic resilience was built through fiscal prudence, infrastructure and banking reforms. She cited 7.8% Q1 FY27 GDP growth and $766 billion forex reserves, while calling for strategic resource security and more private investment.

When: 2026-10-03 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Nirmala Sitharaman · **Prelims:** India's Q1 FY27 GDP growth was recorded at 7.8 percent.; India's forex reserves stood at USD 766 billion.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Demonstrates India's macroeconomic stability and growth leadership amidst global headwinds.; Highlights the effectiveness of recent fiscal policies, banking reforms, and capital buffers like forex reserves.*

Static — Fiscal prudence involves responsible government spending and revenue management to keep fiscal deficits within sustainable limits and control public debt. Foreign exchange reserves are assets held by a central bank in foreign currencies, used to back liabilities and influence monetary policy. Gross Domestic Product (GDP) measures the total monetary value of finished goods and services produced within a country over a specific time period.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, Governance & Policy, Science & Technology · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

Mint: read the source

GS2 GS3 MAKE NOTES

India–European Free Trade Association Pact: A Milestone in Economic Cooperation

The India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement between India, Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, and Switzerland marked one year of implementation after entering into force on October 1, 2025. The agreement serves as a strategic manifestation of India's Atmanirbhar Bharat goal and EFTA's quest for resilient, varied economic partnerships. A core point of debate and discussion surrounds meeting the ambitious 15-year target of attracting $100 billion in foreign direct investment and creating 1 million direct jobs. EFTA provided tariff discounts on 92.2 percent of tariff lines covering 99.6 percent of India's exports, while India offered access on 82.7 percent of tariff lines representing 95.3 percent of EFTA exports. Sensitive domestic sectors including dairy, soya, coal, pharmaceuticals, medical devices, and certain food goods are protected through exclusions or progressive tariff reductions, with gold import tariffs remaining unchanged. The pact encompasses 14 chapters covering goods, services, rules of origin, intellectual property rights, investment promotion, trade remedies, and sustainable development. Operational since February 2025, the India-EFTA Desk facilitates investments, joint ventures, and SME collaborations in sectors like renewable energy, life sciences, engineering, and digital technologies.

When: 2026-10-03 · **Where:** India, Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, Switzerland · **Who:** India and the European Free Trade Association countries · **Prelims:** The India-EFTA TEPA entered into force on October 1, 2025.; EFTA members include Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, and Switzerland.; EFTA committed to boost FDI in India by $100 billion over 15 years.

> ***Why it matters —*** *It marks India's first Free Trade Agreement with four developed European economies.; It aims to secure $100 billion in foreign direct investments and generate 1 million direct jobs over 15 years.*

Static — The European Free Trade Association is an intergovernmental organization founded in 1960 by its then seven member states to promote free trade and economic integration. Current EFTA members include four European nations: Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway, and Switzerland, operating alongside the European Union and the UK as major European economic blocs. Free Trade Agreements are legally binding treaties between two or more nations designed to reduce or eliminate import and export duties and barriers to trade.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

NEXT IAS: read the source

Environment & Ecology

GS3 MAKE NOTES

In culmination of 10 years of dedicated efforts, Union Environment Minister and CM (Rajasthan) initiate the process for release of captive-bred Great Indian Bustards into the Wild at Desert National Park, Jaislamer

Captive-bred Great Indian Bustards are being released into the wild for the first time as part of a conservation breeding program. In a significant milestone for the conservation of the critically endangered Great Indian Bustard (GIB), Union Minister for Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Shri Bhupender Yadav, and Chief Minister (Rajasthan), Shri Bhajan Lal Sharma (through VC), today participated in the initiation of the process for release of two captive-bred Great Indian Bustards from the soft-release facility into an enclosure to be undertaken tomorrow at the Desert National Park, Jaisalmer. This rewilding of the GIB is the fruit of continuous hard work, dedication and scientific pursuit over a decade in building a viable population of the State bird of Rajasthan. The dignitaries also reviewed the progress of GI Bhupender Yadav said the milestone was the outcome of nearly a decade of unwavering dedication by our scientists, researchers, and ground staff to help the Great Indian Bustard, a critically endangered bird, reclaim the deserts of Rajasthan The release marks a new phase in the conservation programme, with experts set to track whether captive-raised birds can survive and reproduce without assistance

When: 2026-10-03 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Conservation authorities and wildlife researchers · **Prelims:** The bird involved in the release is the Great Indian Bustard.; This is the first time captive-bred individuals are being released into the wild.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Represents a critical turning point for the prevention of the extinction of the Great Indian Bustard.; Tests the efficacy of ex-situ conservation and soft-release methodologies for critically endangered Indian avifauna.*

Static — The Great Indian Bustard (Ardeotis nigriceps) is a critically endangered bird native to the Indian subcontinent. Its primary habitat consists of dry grasslands and scrublands, with the largest remaining population in Rajasthan. The species is protected under Schedule I of the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972, offering it the highest level of legal protection in India.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology · Prelims angle: Species, Place in news

PIB: read the source · also reported by Hindustan Times, Swarajya, ForumIAS, Drishti IAS

GS3 MAKE NOTES

CAFE Smokescreen

India has notified CAFE-III norms to govern passenger vehicles from 1 April 2027 to 31 March 2032, replacing the earlier CAFE-II phase. The norms aim to improve fuel efficiency and reduce carbon dioxide emissions through progressively tighter consumption targets, EV super-credits, and technology credits. Critics argue that the weight-sensitive design allows heavier vehicles to receive higher permissible fuel consumption limits despite requiring greater percentage improvements. The fuel-consumption benchmark tightens from 3.996 litres per 100 km in 2027-28 to 3.3273 litres per 100 km in 2031-32, exceeding a 16% improvement. Manufacturers will report vehicle performance under both the Modified Indian Driving Cycle and the Worldwide Harmonized Light Vehicles Test Procedure starting in April 2027. EV 3x super-credits count one battery electric vehicle as three vehicles in fleet-average calculations, which critics say could mask actual internal combustion engine output. Eligible manufacturers can benefit from 12 recognised fuel-saving technologies, gaining compliance credits capped at 9 grams per kilometre. A market-based credit-debit mechanism allows manufacturers exceeding targets to trade credits, while small manufacturers producing under 1,000 vehicles are exempt from fleet obligations.

When: 1 April 2027 to 31 March 2032 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Bureau of Energy Efficiency and automobile manufacturers · **Prelims:** CAFE-III norms apply from 1 April 2027 to 31 March 2032.; The fuel consumption benchmark tightens from 3.996 litres/100 km in 2027-28 to 3.3273 litres/100 km in 2031-32.; Manufacturers can receive compliance benefits for 12 recognised fuel-saving technologies, capped at 9 g/km.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Stricter fleet-average targets lower overall fossil-fuel consumption and support India's long-term energy security.; The five-year regulatory roadmap gives automobile manufacturers predictability for technology planning and green investments.*

Static — Corporate Average Fuel Economy norms are mandatory fuel-efficiency standards requiring automobile manufacturers to keep their fleet average fuel consumption within prescribed limits. India introduced its first phase of CAFE norms in 2017 under the Energy Conservation Act, 2001, making manufacturers responsible for average fleet efficiency. Unlike Bharat Stage norms that regulate harmful tailpipe pollutants like NOx and particulate matter, CAFE standards specifically focus on fleet-level fuel efficiency and CO2 emissions.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, Infrastructure & Energy

ForumIAS: read the source

Science & Technology

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India’s First 5.56 km FreeSpace Quantum Key Distribution Link Demonstrated

India successfully demonstrated its first free-space Quantum Key Distribution link over a distance of 5.56 kilometres. The field trial was carried out on the night of September 27-28 in a collaboration between QNu Labs, BISAG-N, and IIT Gandhinagar. The secure channel was established between BISAG-N and IIT Gandhinagar using QNu Labs' Pointing, Acquisition and Tracking system. The trial achieved a stable Quantum Bit Error Rate of below 5 per cent and generated secure encryption keys at 230-260 bits per second. The generated keys were integrated with BISAG-N's Vedic Kavach platform, enabling end-to-end encryption and decryption of test messages. The setup combined hardware-based QKD device Armos with software-based post-quantum cryptography and quantum random number generation. The integrated architecture is designed to maintain security even if the physical quantum communication channel is temporarily unavailable. The demonstration paves the way for developing longer-distance quantum-secure networks and satellite-based quantum communication systems. The project strengthens India's secure communication infrastructure against emerging cybersecurity risks in the quantum era.

When: September 27-28 · **Where:** BISAG-N and IIT Gandhinagar · **Who:** QNu Labs, BISAG-N, IIT Gandhinagar, Dr. Vinay Thakur, Sunil Gupta, Cmde Manish Tripathi · **Prelims:** Distance of the free-space QKD link: 5.56 km; Date of the field trial: Night of September 27-28; Quantum Bit Error Rate achieved: Below 5 per cent

> ***Why it matters —*** *Reduces reliance on physical fibre-optic networks by enabling optical key transmission through open air.; Lays the foundation for future long-distance and satellite-based quantum communication networks for India.*

Static — Quantum Key Distribution (QKD) is a secure communication method that uses quantum mechanics to exchange cryptographic keys between parties with theoretical security. Free-space QKD transmits cryptographic keys through open air using optical channels instead of traditional fibre-optic cables, facilitating satellite communication. Quantum Bit Error Rate (QBER) measures the ratio of error bits to total transferred bits in a quantum communication channel, indicating link stability.

Syllabus: GS3: Science & Technology

PIB: read the source · free copy on msn.com

Defence

GS3 MAKE NOTES

India may finalise 114 Rafale fighter jet deal with France by current financial year: IAF chief

India is looking at finalising the multi-role fighter aircraft deal to procure 114 Rafale fighter jets by the current financial year. The push follows a clearance in February for the procurement under a government-to-government framework with France to boost IAF combat prowess. Price negotiations and other critical project issues are currently underway between India and France. The IAF Chief stated that the force may look at alternative platforms like Russian Su-57 jets if the domestic AMCA programme faces delays. The Air Force needs at least 36 to 40 aircraft annually in the next few years to address depleting fighter squadron strength. The IAF leadership emphasised modernising through artificial intelligence and achieving self-reliance by producing indigenous fighter jet engines.

When: Current financial year · **Where:** New Delhi, India · **Who:** Air Chief Marshal A P Singh, Indian Air Force · **Prelims:** Number of Rafale jets in the proposed deal: 114.; Framework of procurement: Government-to-government framework with France.; Target timeframe for deal finalisation: Current financial year.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Addresses the depleting strength of IAF fighter squadrons by aiming for 36-40 aircraft additions annually.; Highlights India's push towards self-reliance in defence manufacturing, including domestic jet engine production.*

Static — Defence acquisitions in India are guided by the Defence Acquisition Procedure (DAP), which sets rules for capital procurements from domestic and foreign sources. Government-to-government (G20) defence deals bypass standard competitive global tenders to fast-track critical military procurements. The Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA) is India's indigenous fifth-generation stealth fighter jet project developed by ADA and DRDO.

Syllabus: GS3: Defence, International Relations

Economic Times: read the source · free copy on theprint.in · also reported by indiatoday.in, Indianmasterminds, Hindustan Times, ndtvprofit.com

History, Art & Culture

GS1 MAKE NOTES

Government approves 5 Centres of Excellence to support Classical languages

The Ministry of Education approved five Centres of Excellence for Classical Assamese, Bengali, Marathi, Pali, and Prakrit. The decision was officially conveyed via an Office Memorandum issued by the Department of Higher Education's Language Division on October 1, 2026. The move follows the Union Cabinet's October 2024 decision to grant classical language status to these five languages. The Classical Assamese centre will be established at Tezpur University in Assam. The Classical Bengali centre will be set up at Visva-Bharati University in West Bengal. The Classical Marathi centre will come up at Deccan College Post-Graduate and Research Institute in Pune, Maharashtra. The Classical Pali centre is assigned to the Central University of Odisha in Sunabeda, Odisha. The Classical Prakrit centre will be housed at the Central University of Gujarat in Vadodara. These centres aim to support academic research, digitisation, preservation, and dissemination of the heritage of these languages.

When: October 1, 2026 · **Where:** Assam, West Bengal, Maharashtra, Odisha, Gujarat · **Who:** Ministry of Education, Department of Higher Education's Language Division · **Prelims:** Five new Centres of Excellence have been approved for Assamese, Bengali, Marathi, Pali, and Prakrit.; The Office Memorandum was issued on October 1, 2026.; The Classical Pali centre will be located at the Central University of Odisha, Sunabeda.

> ***Why it matters —*** *Provides institutional backing for the academic research, digitisation, and preservation of ancient Indian languages.; Expands the formal footprint of India's classical linguistic heritage from classrooms and archives into dedicated research spaces.*

Static — The Union Cabinet grants classical language status to languages based on criteria like high antiquity of early texts over 1,500 to 2,000 years. Other criteria include a valuable body of ancient literature considered a heritage by generations of speakers, and original literary traditions. Before the 2024 addition, six languages enjoyed classical status: Tamil, Sanskrit, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, and Odia.

Syllabus: GS1: History, Art & Culture

indiatoday.in: read the source · also reported by The Hindu, NDTV

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

SOCIAL JUSTICE & WELFARE SCHEME QUICK READ

Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana

The Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment organised a distribution programme under the Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana in Delhi-NCR. During this programme, 662 assistive devices were provided to 114 senior citizens. The Rashtriya Vayoshri Yojana is a first-of-its-kind central scheme providing physical aids and assisted-living devices for BPL senior citizens. The scheme is implemented by the Artificial Limbs Manufacturing Corporation, a PSU under the nodal ministry.

ForumIAS: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY ACT/BILL/RULES QUICK READ

Mapping of two Western Ghats districts shows much of proposed ESA overlaps with Notified Forests, Protected Areas, or existing ESZs

The mapping was released to clear misconceptions among residents regarding how the draft ESA notification affects them. A citizen-led initiative mapped two Western Ghats districts to show that the proposed Ecologically Sensitive Area largely overlaps with existing protected forests and zones. Citizen-led initiative breaks down the draft ESA notification for two districts to clear misconceptions about how it affects residents

The Hindu: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION APPOINTMENT QUICK READ

Appointments Committee of the Cabinet approves appointment of 02 senior IPS officers as Special Directors in CBI

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet approved the appointment of two senior Indian Police Service officers as Special Directors in the CBI on October 1, 2026. The two officers elevated are AYV Krishna and N. Venugopal, both belonging to the 1995 batch. The decision upgrades their existing posts from Additional Director carrying Level 15 of the Pay Matrix to Special Director carrying Level 16.

indianmasterminds.com: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS | PLACE IN NEWS | QUICK READ

5 Indians rescued after Kuwait-flagged tanker hit by projectile in Strait of Hormuz

Five Indian nationals aboard the Kuwait-flagged crude oil tanker MT Kazimah III were safely rescued after the vessel was struck by a projectile. The attack occurred while the tanker was sailing through the strategic Strait of Hormuz en route to the port of Lomé in Togo. The Indian embassy in Oman coordinated the rescue operation and confirmed that all five Indian crew members were safely shifted ashore.

Times of India: source

GOVERNANCE & POLICY | ACT/BILL/RULES | QUICK READ

Chhattisgarh Cabinet Approves Rules to Enforce 10% Quota for Ex-Agniveers in State Jobs

The Chhattisgarh Cabinet approved the Chhattisgarh Public Service Former Agniveer Soldiers Recruitment Rules, 2026 to operationalize job quotas. The decision establishes the administrative framework, eligibility conditions, and selection process to implement the already approved 10% quota. This move provides structured employment opportunities and supports the rehabilitation of youth who complete their service under the Agnipath Scheme.

indianmasterminds.com: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION | JUDGMENT | QUICK READ

AP to move SC against HC verdict on 34% BC quota

The Andhra Pradesh government decided to file a Special Leave Petition in the Supreme Court against the High Court verdict striking down enhanced BC quotas. Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu directed the Advocate General and legal department officials to file the petition and engage senior advocates.

thehansindia.com: source

AGRICULTURE & ALLIED | QUICK READ

Surendranagar’s Wadhwani Chilli Gets GI Tag Push, Applicati…

The move aims to provide official recognition and legal protection to the regional chilli variety. An application has been filed to secure a Geographical Indication (GI) tag for the Wadhwani chilli grown in Surendranagar, Gujarat.

GujaratSamachar English: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | SPECIES | PLACE IN NEWS | QUICK READ

New Lizard Species Identified in Pakhala Wildlife Sanctuary In Telangana's Warangal

Scientists discovered two new lizard species, Hemidactylus cairnicola and Hemidactylus koyaorum, in Telangana's Nalgonda and Warangal districts. The discovery raises the total number of endemic reptile species in Telangana to six. The findings were published in the European Journal of Taxonomy following joint field research. The research was conducted by institutions including the Zoological Survey of India, Wildlife Institute of India, and Fakir Mohan University.

telanganatoday.com: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY | SPECIES | QUICK READ

Simply Put: New species discovered

It was highlighted in a recent report by Down To Earth. A newly discovered species has been reported in recent scientific literature.

Down To Earth: source

DEFENCE | EXERCISE | QUICK READ

Exercise Yudh Abhyas 2026, Objectives, Importance, Latest News

The 22nd edition of the bilateral India-US military drill, Exercise Yudh Abhyas 2026, commenced in September 2026. The annual exercise is conducted to advance interoperability, military cooperation, and joint operational planning between both armies. The core focus addresses evolving security challenges through joint operations in mountainous and semi-mountainous operational terrains. The joint training is hosted across the Auli Foreign Training Node in Uttarakhand and Rajasthan's Mahajan Field Firing Range.

vajiramandravi.com: source

DEFENCE | EXERCISE | QUICK READ

Ambassador Gor at Joint Military Exercise, Touts India Partnership

U.S. and Indian troops have wrapped up the 22nd iteration of the major joint military exercise Yudh Abhyas. The exercise aimed to strengthen battlefield coordination, improve interoperability, and counter China's growing influence over Asia. Roughly 600 soldiers from each country participated in training across Auli in Uttarakhand and the Mahajan Field Firing Range in Rajasthan.

msn.com: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS QUICK READ

Russia to take 70,000 Indian skilled workers this year, Jaishankar tells parliamentary panel

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar briefed a parliamentary consultative committee on India's multifaceted engagement with Russia, covering trade, energy, and diplomacy. Russia has agreed to accept approximately 70,000 skilled Indian workers this year, with a particular focus on construction and logistics sectors. Both nations share an ambition to expand bilateral trade more balanced by increasing Indian exports across seven specific sectors like pharmaceuticals and engineering goods.

BusinessLine: source

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY AGREEMENT/MOU QUICK READ

Ministry of Ayush, IndiaAI Sign MoU to Advance AI in Traditional Medicine

The Ministry of Ayush and the IndiaAI Mission signed an MoU to promote Artificial Intelligence across the Ayush sector. The partnership focuses on research, digital innovation, medicinal plants, drug administration and capacity building. The Ministry of Ayush will onboard the AIKosh platform by sharing eligible health research artefacts and datasets. The collaboration provides access to GPU-based high-performance computing infrastructure through IndiaAI at subsidised rates.

ddnews.gov.in: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY SPECIES PLACE IN NEWS QUICK READ

Chhattisgarh tiger reserve finds 2,500 trees girdled. Satellite images show scale

The discovery of 2,500 girdled trees and the use of satellite imagery to map the destruction put the tiger reserve in the news. Authorities in a Chhattisgarh tiger reserve discovered about 2,500 trees were illegally girdled, with the scale confirmed through satellite images.

Indian Express: source

DEFENCE EXERCISE QUICK READ

Exercise VARUNA 2026, Date, Host, India-France Defence Cooperation

Exercise VARUNA 2026 marks the 24th edition of the annual bilateral maritime exercise between the Indian Navy and the French Navy. The 2026 edition was hosted by France at the Toulon Naval Base located on the Mediterranean coast from September 22 to September 28, 2026. The core objective is to enhance operational coordination, interoperability, experience sharing, and mutual understanding between both navies.

vajiramandravi.com: source

ECONOMY QUICK READ

India GDP forecast stays at 7%, uncertainty range remains wide: NITI Aayog's Arvind Virmani

NITI Aayog Member Arvind Virmani retained his India GDP growth forecast at 7 per cent for the year. Virmani cited unresolved trade issues and global developments as the reasons for maintaining a wide uncertainty range of plus or minus 1 per cent. The core issue involves balancing macroeconomic forecasts against global uncertainties and transitioning the UPI payment ecosystem towards a cost-based system.

Economic Times: source

HEALTH QUICK READ

After Chandrayaan-3, ICMR asks scientists to attempt the 'impossible' in healthcare

The Indian Council of Medical Research has launched the First in the World Challenge to invite breakthrough health technology projects. The initiative seeks innovations in vaccines, drugs, therapeutics, and diagnostics that have never been thought of, tested, or tried anywhere globally. The scheme offers funding of up to Rs 8 crore for a single project based on the advancement of the proposed innovation.

Times of India: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS QUICK READ

Ethiopia At The 18th BRICS Summit

The event was reported as Ethiopia engaged in the 18th BRICS Summit. Ethiopia participated in the 18th BRICS Summit as a member of the expanded bloc.

thereporterethiopia.com: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS QUICK READ

Chargé d'Affaires of the Pakistan High Commission summoned by Ministry of External Affairs

The Ministry of External Affairs summoned the Chargé d'Affaires of the Pakistan High Commission in New Delhi to lodge a strong protest against illegal cross-border infiltration. The MEA strongly rejected allegations made by Pakistan regarding an October 2 incident in the Ferozepur sector of Punjab along the International Border as baseless and motivated.

timesofindia.indiatimes.com: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS QUICK READ

G20 debate exposes doubts over WTO tools

A majority of G20 members raised doubts about the effectiveness of existing WTO-authorised measures in tackling structural excess capacity. The assessment emerged from the G20 Trade Ministerial held in Milwaukee under the US presidency on September 30 and October 1. Trade ministers discussed structural excess capacity alongside weaponisation of food, forced labour, and Most-Favoured Nation reform.

lokmattimes.com: source

HISTORY, ART & CULTURE QUICK READ

Jaipur’s Walled City races to meet UNESCO deadline for heritage plan

Jaipur's Walled City is racing to meet UNESCO's December 2 deadline for submitting the Special Area Heritage Development Plan. The strict timeline is driven by the urgent need to retain the city's World Heritage status and avoid penalties. The core issue is whether local authorities can finalize the draft plan and stakeholder consultations amidst tight schedules.

timesofindia.indiatimes.com: source

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS2 Chief election commissioner Kahaniyan: There are CECs, and there are CECs — no matter their personalities, their looks have hardly been deceptive

An opinion piece reflecting on the historical impact, diverse personalities, and evolving challenges faced by Chief Election Commissioners in India. There is a vital influence of Chief Election Commissioners in shaping India's electoral landscape. It celebrates the pivotal efforts of CECs like TN Seshan, MS Gill, and JM Lyngdoh, whose actions tackled issues like disenfranchisement and electoral malfeasance. Meanwhile, Gyanesh Kumar's current leadership faces scrutiny amid ongoing debates regarding the effectiveness of the Election Commission.

Economic Times

GS2 GS3 Punjab’s drug mission remained unfinished

The author reflects on the drug menace in Punjab, asserting that governments must be judged by their actual actions and shortcomings rather than political slogans. Upon assuming office in March 2017, the government initiated a major crackdown and formed a Special Task Force directly answerable to the Chief Minister. The policy followed a zero-tolerance approach without a witch-hunt, leading to arrests within police ranks and registering 62,744 drug-related arrests by September 2021.

tribuneindia.com

GS2 Flydubai attack, UK base arrests: Terror shadow looms as war rages on, US and Israel head for polls

The ongoing US-Israel war against Iran has entered its eighth month with no durable agreement in sight to end hostilities. A recent attempt by an Arab co-pilot to crash Flydubai flight FZ1073 and arrests of British nationals planning attacks on RAF Fairford underscore rising aviation security threats. The US withdrew all its troops from Iraq on September 30 under a bilateral agreement despite unresolved concerns over Iran-aligned armed groups.

msn.com

GS3 Mismatch mess : Genuine paddy farmers must not suffer

The Haryana paddy procurement process faces severe delays as nearly 59% of crop areas flagged as mismatched remain awaiting verification. Out of 22.35 lakh acres marked as mismatched, only 9.14 lakh acres were verified by September 28. Farmers in Yamunanagar have protested because database discrepancies between registered and verified acreage are holding up paddy purchases. The Meri Fasal Mera Byora portal was originally intended to increase transparency and prevent bogus claims in government support.

tribuneindia.com

GS3 Russia-Ukraine war is hitting India’s food and fertiliser security. Delhi has a role to play

The Russia-Ukraine war is severely impacting global food and fertiliser security, with wheat prices at a two-year high and shipping routes becoming harder to use. The Black Sea region accounts for one-third of global wheat trade and 63 per cent of sunflower oil exports, making import-dependent nations like India highly vulnerable. The core issue is that developing nations in the Global South are forced to absorb economic and supply shocks caused by distant conflicts they did not create.

ThePrint

GS1 GS2 A long road to gender parity

India scored 64.5% on gender parity, showing a minor 0.4 percentage-point increase over last year but remaining below the global average of 69.2%. The author highlights that while the global gender gap closure timeline is estimated at 120 years, India faces an even taller task due to deep-seated challenges. The core issue is that educational gains among women are not translating into employment, driven by low female labour force participation and an income gap.

Deccan Herald

GS1 Best of BS Opinion: What Chinese archives reveal about the 1962 war

The opinions were published in Business Standard to analyze historical and contemporary geopolitical and economic trends. A compilation of opinion pieces examining historical insights from Chinese archives on the 1962 war, economic concerns over AI investments, India's hard power, and US-China ties. Today's opinions examine a possible diplomatic opening before the 1962 India-China war, fears of an AI investment bubble, India's use of hard power and the evolving US-China relationship

Business Standard

GS2 Unwise to ignore what Xi's US visit pageantry masked

Chinese President Xi Jinping's state visit to the US was marked by extraordinary pageantry and modest deliverables, consolidating a new stage in great power relations. The recalibration of ties was triggered by China's forceful retaliation against US tariffs in April 2025 using its monopoly over rare earth magnets. The core issue is a K-shaped relationship where high-level diplomacy coexists with robust competition in trade, technology, and military domains.

Hindustan Times

GS3 How not to restore a forest — the inept dismantling of Delhi's Central Ridge

The Delhi Forest Department is using the excuse of removing invasive vilayati keekar to clear 200 hectares of the Central Ridge over the last three months. Bulldozers have ploughed up the soil and swept away natural woody shrubs and lianas as part of an afforestation plan prescribed by the Forest Research Institute. The author argues that the ongoing restoration work is a deadly cocktail of ignorance and ineptitude, causing irreversible damage to the ecosystem.

msn.com

GS3 A free economy needs controls, not a Control-Raj: MA Sreenivasan

The editorial discusses whether controls are antithetical to a free economy or necessary for true freedom to flourish. The author argues that enemies of freedom exploit the perceived contradiction between freedom and control to promote regimentation. The text warns that confusing liberty with laissez-faire or the law of the jungle conditions people to accept strict state control. The author shares personal experience of having administered controls for a few years under a Maharaja's regime.

ThePrint

GS2 More teeth for the aviation regulator

A committee has recommended transforming the Directorate General of Civil Aviation into a statutory Civil Aviation Authority of India. The DGCA currently operates as an attached office of the civil aviation ministry with nearly half of its 1,630 sanctioned posts vacant. Recent systemic failures include an Air India crash in Ahmedabad killing 260 people and an IndiGo schedule collapse affecting over 300,000 passengers. Indian aviation has become a duopoly, leaving the current weak regulator unable to penalize major airlines without stranding travelers.

Hindustan Times

GS2 GS3 Nepal's call for climate justice

A month after devastating floods in Nepal, three major climate narratives have emerged regarding the past, present, and future of climate action in the Himalayas. Scientists and ICIMOD warn that melting rates in the Himalayan region have doubled since pre-2000 levels, making disasters like recent floods and landslides inevitable. Poor countries continue to bear heavy costs of climate inaction despite repeated global warnings, such as UN Secretary General Antonio Guterres highlighting rapid glacial melt.

Hindustan Times

GS3 From one AI to another

Akamai Technologies expanded its partnership with frontier AI lab Anthropic through an agreement worth nearly $12 billion. Anthropic committed to spending $11.6 billion over seven years on dedicated cloud capacity for CPU workloads, with an option for an additional $9 billion. Unlike typical AI contracts focused on GPUs, this deal centers on CPUs for general-purpose computing and agentic workloads. GF Securities suggests the deal will benefit Nvidia because the infrastructure is expected to use Nvidia's Vera CPUs.

Mint

GS1 GS4 In democracy's journey to future, Gandhi is the wise guide and co-traveller

The author examines Mahatma Gandhi's relevance for imagining the future trajectories of Indian democracy, building on a recent article by Yogendra Yadav. While Gandhi is widely celebrated as a symbol of protest politics and non-violent Satyagraha, he is rarely viewed as a figure for institutional building. Although Gandhi was critical of the modern state and identified as a philosophical anarchist, his writings reveal a strong constructive impulse for alternative public institutions.

msn.com

GS2 SIR fallout : Need to streamline teachers' duties

The Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls faces intense scrutiny for administrative issues and allegations of disenfranchising eligible citizens. The Election Commission of India directed state poll officials to launch a special drive to include left-out and new voters in completed areas. The ongoing third phase of the massive SIR exercise has placed heavy burdens on government school teachers acting as Booth Level Officers.

tribuneindia.com

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

Cybersecurity – Significance & Challenges A recent ransomware leak exposed blueprints and supplier data for the Kudankulam Nuclear Plant through a third-party contractor, highlighting operational vulnerabilities. The breach demonstrates how cyber espionage and third-party supply chain risks threaten critical infrastructure despite isolated core reactor networks.
ForumIAS

When Election Commission was rocked by internal disputes The article revisits past controversies involving high-profile Election Commissioners to provide context on internal institutional friction. This explainer details historical internal disputes and institutional clashes within the Election Commission of India.
The Hindu

Reintroduction of tigers in Buxa: What it means for conservation The release of a tigress in Buxa and the official PIB statement detailing the conservation goals put the reserve in the news. An explanation of the tiger reintroduction initiative in Buxa Tiger Reserve and its long-term conservation objectives.
The Hindu

The tussle for top posts in India's CAPFs: IPS officers or force veterans? The discussion resurfaced around the allocation of leadership roles within the Central Armed Police Forces. An explainer on the structural dispute between IPS officers on deputation and cadre-promoted officers over senior appointments in India's CAPFs.
ForumIAS

Why Allahabad High Court said hookah service is banned in designated smoking areas The ruling came out as the court examined regulations governing hookah services in public spaces. The Allahabad High Court clarified that providing hookah services in designated smoking areas is not permitted under the law.
Indian Express

Expert explains | As Israel heads to polls this month, will unpopular Netanyahu make a comeback? Israel is heading to the polls this month. An explainer detailing the political scenario in Israel as the country prepares for parliamentary elections and the prospects of Benjamin Netanyahu.
Indian Express

When AI agents slip the leash: How companies monitor and control them The growing adoption of autonomous AI agents in corporate environments has heightened concerns over monitoring and safety control. This article explains the methods and frameworks companies use to monitor and control autonomous AI agents to prevent unintended behaviors.
Indian Express

How did social media rumours in Punjab lead to protests at two private universities? The incident gained prominence following widespread student demonstrations sparked by viral digital misinformation. Unverified social media rumours triggered student protests and law and order concerns at Chitkara University and Lovely Professional University in Punjab. What happened in Chitkara University and Lovely Professional University?
The Hindu

Explainer: Why Some Indian Exporters Have To Pay Europe For Carbon Emissions In India The implementation of the European Union's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism has triggered reporting requirements and cost implications for Indian exporters. Certain Indian exporters are required to account for and potentially pay for carbon emissions associated with their manufacturing processes when exporting to Europe under the EU's carbon border rules.
ETV Bharat

Explainer: Why tiger poaching concerns are growing The Centre allocated Rs 50 crore to the National Tiger Conservation Authority 18 years ago to help states form the Special Tiger Protection Force to curb poaching. Very few states have constituted the STPF two decades later, leading to heightened poaching and unnatural deaths with over 100 tigers killed in three years.
tribuneindia.com

Explainer: What Did South Asia Tell the World at UNGA 81? The convening of the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly put the spotlight on statements made by South Asian leaders. This explainer details the key messages, diplomatic positions, and regional priorities articulated by South Asian nations at the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly.
India's World

3D concrete printing houses breaking ground in Andhra Pradesh The technology entered news discussions as 3D concrete printing houses broke ground in Andhra Pradesh. An explainer on how 3D concrete printing works, its application in housing construction in Andhra Pradesh, and its potential impact on Indian infrastructure. Could it transform the way rural homes are built in India?
The Hindu

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- Sanctions, tariffs sometimes weaponised as policy tools: PK Mishra (Economy) Business Standard
- Understanding carbon debt, factors behind BRICS stance on fossil fuels, and why it matters at COP31 (Environment & Ecology) Hindustan Times

- RBI backs blockchain technology, remains cautious on crypto: Guv Malhotra (Economy) Business Standard
- Swachh Bharat Mission-Gramin (Governance & Policy) Drishti IAS
- "Gaganyaan prioritises human safety, reliability over optimum performance": ISRO's K Sivan (Science & Technology) ANI News
- Valmiki Tiger Reserve (Environment & Ecology) ForumIAS
- Sheikh Hasina’s extradition possible via ‘well-structured’ process: India’s High Commissioner to Bangladesh (International Relations) The Hindu
- India unlikely to face major food crisis despite global disruptions: 16th Finance Commission Chairman (Economy) BusinessLine
- Shri Harivansh Leads Indian Parliamentary Delegation to 153rd IPU Assembly in Tanzania (International Relations) PIB
- PM-SETU: One Year of Transforming India’s ITIs (Education) PIB
- Organ donation in India: How the system works and what law says (Health) ForumIAS
- Farmers’ body protests delay in payment for maize procured under MSP (Agriculture & Allied) The Hindu
- Vast majority of G20 countries reject US stance on excess industrial capacity, forced labour (International Relations) BusinessLine
- Resilience of financial system not a guarantee against future vulnerabilities: RBI Guv (Economy) BusinessLine
- INDIAN NAVAL SHIPS SAHYADRI AND KULISH CONCLUDE PARTICIPATION IN AIME 2026 (Defence) PIB
- Inside Bandhavgarh’s forests: The evolving nature of tiger tourism (Environment & Ecology) The Hindu
- Canadian Hydrogen Intensity Mapping Experiment (CHIME) Telescope (Science & Technology) ForumIAS
- Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal says India’s free trade agreements to cover 75 % of world economies (Economy) All India Radio (NewsOnAir)
- The price floor India forgot: Why livestock farmers deserve an MSP too! (Agriculture & Allied) BusinessLine
- SECI, Hintco Agree on Framework for Indo-German RFNBO Tender (Economy) Energetica India Magazine
- Karnataka seeks Rs. 7,143 crore Central aid for drought relief (Disaster Management) The Hindu
- AU–BRICS: A Strategic Partnership That Reinforces Global South (International Relations) Trendsnafrica
- IMF Warning To Pakistan: Circular Debt Breach, Rising Inflation & Gulf Conflict Risks | News18 (International Relations) News18
- NCW proposes gender-neutral child care leave, 5 lakh creche seats by 2030 (Social Justice & Welfare) Hindustan Times
- Narmada River (Origin, Tributaries & Dams) UPSC CSE (Geography) NEXT IAS
- Exercise restraint on interim relief in disciplinary cases: Supreme Court to High Courts (Polity & Constitution) Deccan Herald
- Ukraine ready to consider India’s ceasefire proposal: FM Sybiha (International Relations) The Hindu
- RBI rate hike in October 2026? SBI sees CPI inflation above 6.5%, but Nuvama asks: What will it fix? (Economy) ET Now
- Yet to begin issuing rejection slips to 1.9 million left out of NRC, Centre tells Supreme Court (Polity & Constitution) Hindustan Times
- Serious about demand for conducting NRC before census: Manipur govt (Internal Security) ThePrint
- India, France review trade and investment cooperation (International Relations) Nagaland Post
- Differences blocked G20 trade outcome: Goyal (International Relations) IANS LIVE
- Post-Facto Environmental Clearance (Environment & Ecology) NEXT IAS
- Next financial crisis may stem from cyberattack or geopolitical shock, RBI governor says (Economy) Economic Times
- Deleted, and left in limbo (Polity & Constitution) The Hindu
- Criminal law not a tool for extortion in matrimonial disputes: Supreme Court (Polity & Constitution) Deccan Herald
- Cabinet Raises MSP for Six Rabi Crops: Wheat Up Rs 25 to Rs 2,610, Mustard and Lentil Rise More (Agriculture & Allied) Bharat Stories
- Fraudulent CIRP Initiation: Supreme Court Rules on Recall Powers and Continuity of Insolvency Proceedings (Economy) TaxCorp AI
- After full implementation of BNS, cases from FIR to Supreme Court will be disposed of in 3 years: Shah (Polity & Constitution) The Hindu
- Post Supreme Court order, Centre streamlines ex-post facto approval for 'illegal' projects (Environment & Ecology) Deccan Herald
- People’s mandate cannot confer unbridled authority on elected representatives: Supreme Court (Polity & Constitution) India Legal
- Calcutta High Court Voids OBC Certificates Issued Under 2025 State Notifications, Says Candidates Must Be ... (Polity & Constitution) Live Law
- Cargo Vessel to Sail from Dibrugarh to Bangladesh (Infrastructure & Energy) Drishti IAS
- 'Most comprehensive plan': Ukraine confirms India playing role in mediating energy truce in Black Sea (International Relations) Times of India
- With suitable examples, discuss how the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) can secure India’s energy demands. Why has its commercial operationalisation faced persistent delays? (International Relations) GKToday
- To counter China, India formally puts Gogra, Hot Spring & others on map (International Relations) Times of India
- “Organisational wrongdoing often survives because responsibility is dispersed across several actors.” Explain the role of diffusion of responsibility in facilitating unethical conduct. How can individual accountability be preserved? (Ethics & Integrity) Insights on India
- From ‘tareekh pe tareekh’ to justice within 3 years: Amit Shah hails BNS, overhaul of criminal laws (Polity & Constitution) Times of India
- PMEGP may get 5-year extension till 2030-31 with Rs 15,000 crore outlay; govt weighs easier norms (Governance & Policy) Economic Times
- Top 10 Innovation Clusters in Global Innovation Index 2026: Bengaluru, Delhi in the top 30 (Economy) The Indian Express

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 19 must-know, 21 Prelims facts, 50 in the news, 15 editorials, 12 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — International Relations (8), Economy (7), Environment & Ecology (6), Polity & Constitution (6), Defence (4), Governance & Policy (2), Science & Technology (2), History, Art & Culture (2), Social Justice & Welfare (1), Agriculture & Allied (1), Health (1). **Nothing today in —** Education, Infrastructure & Energy, Internal Security, Disaster Management, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): 4 · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 1 · Political change in the neighbourhood: 1 · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: 1 · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: 2

Full text — 46 of 67 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — msn.com 5, The Hindu 5, ForumIAS 4, Indian Express 4, tribuneindia.com 4, PIB 3, Mint 3, Economic Times 3, ddnews.gov.in 3, Hindustan Times 3, NEXT IAS 2, thehansindia.com 2, indianmasterminds.com 2, Times of India 2

Built 04 Nov 2026, 00:02 IST by UPSC Intel. Notes quote the reports; check the source before quoting a figure in an answer.